PROMISE & PRACTICE · GROWTH & CONFLICT · SOURCE ANALYSIS

# The Compromises That Failed

*The pattern — and the question*

**Name:** _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

**WHAT I CAN DO TODAY** I can read primary sources about The Compromises That Failed, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

**Directions.** For thirty years, whenever slavery threatened to split the country in two, the nation's leaders did the same thing: they struck a deal, drew a line, balanced the interests, and bought a few more years of peace. It had worked, more or less, since the Missouri Compromise of 1820




*Bleeding Kansas — political cartoon, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## THE SOURCES

## YOUR WORK

### THE PRACTICE — WHO PAID, AND HOW? WHAT DID DRAWING A LINE NOT SOLVE?

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_____

_____

## THE PRACTICE — WHO PAID FOR THIS DEAL, AND HOW? THINK ABOUT THE FUGITIVE SLAVE ACT.

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## THE PRACTICE — WHAT CAN A STORY DO THAT A FACT CANNOT? WHAT EFFECT DID IT HAVE?

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## THE PRACTICE — WHAT DID THIS DEAL HAVE TO DESTROY TO WORK, AND WHAT DID IT SET OFF?

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## SOME QUESTIONS, THE AUTHOR WRITES, CANNOT BE SPLIT DOWN THE MIDDLE. "YOU CANNOT HALF-FREE A HUMAN BEING." USING AT LEAST TWO OF THE DEALS ABOVE, EXPLAIN WHY THE COMPROMISES FAILED.

Some questions, the author writes, cannot be split down the middle. "You cannot half-free a human being." Using at least two of the deals above, explain why the compromises failed.

# TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Compromises That Failed

**The practice — who paid, and how? What did drawing a line not solve?:** Open response.

*Look for a response along the lines of: “"The line kept the peace for a while, but it did not solve… because…"”*

**The practice — who paid for this deal, and how? Think about the Fugitive Slave Act.:** Open response.

*Look for a response along the lines of: “"The deal was supposed to calm things down, but the Fugitive Slave Act actually… because it forced…"”*

**The practice — what can a story do that a fact cannot? What effect did it have?:** Open response.

*Look for a response along the lines of: “"Facts about slavery had been around for years, but a story could… and that mattered because…"”*

**The practice — what did this deal have to destroy to work, and what did it set off?:** Open response.

*Look for a response along the lines of: “"To let the settlers vote, the Act had to… and the result was…"”*

**Some questions, the author writes, cannot be split down the middle. "You cannot half-free a human being." Using at least two of the deals above, explain why the compromises failed.:** Open response.

*Look for a response along the lines of: “Sentence starters: "The compromises failed because…" · "For example, the _____ of _____ tried to… but instead…" · "This shows that some questions cannot be compromised because…"”*